

THE WEIGHT OF QUIET

Written by

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Working title. One continuous shot, no cuts.
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FADE IN:

EXT. LAKE DISTRICT COTTAGE / FELLS - DUSK

Black. Then the grey ridge of mountains against darker sky.

The camera hangs high above a stone cottage. A single downstairs window burns gold.

It begins to descend. Not a fall. A glide. It snakes down through the cold, tilting toward the light the way a thing comes home.

Closer. The window. The sill. It slips through the gap where the pane sits open.

INT. COTTAGE - LIVING ROOM - CONTINUOUS

And into the warmth.

Two mugs sit abandoned on a side table. One still steaming. One stone cold.

MAYA, 30s, stands by the window. Coat still on. Everything about her is finished except this conversation.

JAMES, 30s, paces. His hands move when he talks. He's been moving for some time.

The camera settles a few feet off his shoulder. He doesn't look at it. But something in him shifts. A small ease. A body that has decided it isn't alone.

MAYA
You're not here.

JAMES
I'm standing right in front of you.

MAYA
Exactly. You're standing. You're not present.

JAMES
I'm present.

MAYA
Half of you is. The other half is somewhere I can't reach.

He turns away from her. Walks to the window. Opens it wider. Cold air rushes in.

MAYA (CONT'D)
Why are you opening that?

JAMES
It's stuffy.

MAYA
It's November. And you're doing it
because you need to not be here.
Even while you're here you're
leaving.

He closes his eyes for a moment. His head tips, a fraction,
toward the space beside him. Toward the camera. Just a
second. A listening.

The camera drifts slightly closer.

Maya watches him watch something she can't see.

MAYA (CONT'D)
There. Right there. Who are you
looking at?

JAMES
No one. I'm not looking at anyone.

MAYA
You went somewhere. You do this
thing where you just disappear and
I'm left standing here talking to a
version of you that's not even in
the room.

JAMES
That's not true.

MAYA
It is. Every time I try to reach
you you're already gone. And I
don't know how to follow you
because you won't tell me where you
go.

JAMES
I'm not going anywhere.

MAYA
Yes, you are. You left two years
ago and you brought half of
yourself back and the rest is still
stuck there with her.

He turns. His jaw tightens.

JAMES

Don't do that.

MAYA

Don't what? Say it out loud? She's the reason you can't be with me. She's the reason you keep one foot out the door no matter what I do.

JAMES

That's not fair.

MAYA

It's the only fair thing here. I scheduled this. I took the time. I brought us here thinking maybe away from everything you could just be here, be present, be with me. But you can't do that because you're not with me. You're with her.

He moves toward the kitchen. She follows him.

MAYA (CONT'D)

And the worst part is I get it. I do. I understand why. But I'm not her. I can't be her. And I'm tired of competing with a ghost.

He stops. Reaches for a mug. One of them. It's cold. He sets it down.

JAMES

You're not competing with anything.

MAYA

I'm competing with memory. With the version of her that exists in your head that's probably better than any real person could be. I'm competing with someone who never disappoints you because she's not here to disappoint you.

He looks toward the camera. Just for a moment. A glance. A question. Then he's back.

JAMES

You don't understand.

MAYA

Then explain it. Help me understand how to live with someone who's living in two places at once. How to love someone who's always half-

looking over his shoulder for a
door that won't open.

He comes toward her. She doesn't move. There's heat between
them. Anger. Need.

JAMES
I do love you.

MAYA
Then be here. Actually be here. Not
your body. You. All of you.

He reaches for her. Pulls her toward him roughly. She bites
his shoulder. Raw. Desperate. He holds her. His face turned
away. His eyes open.

For a moment they're pressed together. Real. Present.

Then his eyes find the camera. Find the space where it
hovers. And something breaks in his face.

He pulls away from her.

MAYA (CONT'D)
What?

JAMES
No.

MAYA
What is it?

He steps back. Takes another step. His hand comes up,
reaching toward the empty air beside him. Toward the camera.
His fingers an inch from the lens.

And he sees it. Really sees it. Sees what he's doing. Sees
the reach. Sees the two mugs and the cold drink and the open
window and the whole shape of the evening.

His face shatters.

JAMES (CONT'D)
(barely)
No.

He steps back from it.

JAMES (CONT'D)
Not tonight. Not now.

The camera follows him. Gentle. It doesn't understand. It
comes closer.

JAMES (CONT'D)
(a roar, ragged, at the
empty air)
FUCK OFF!

The camera flinches.

Then it BOLTS. A hard rush back, away from him, across the room, past the cold mug, out through the gap in the window.

EXT. COTTAGE / FELS - CONTINUOUS

Out into the cold and UP. Fast. Climbing hard. The gold window shrinking beneath it.

The mountains. The landscape. The dark.

It stops, high above the roof. Looks down.

Down at the little lit cottage. Down at the one warm window with the man standing in it. Small now. Both hands over his face.

Maya visible behind him. Watching. Confused.

The camera holds there in the dark. Tilted down. The way you look back at a place you have just been thrown out of.

The way an intruder looks at a house.

FADE OUT.